

Frank Gehry

Some of the most important works of contemporary architecture have been produced by Canadian-born Frank Gehry (b.1929), who combines both innovative and ordinary materials with expressive, often startling forms. Moving to Los Angeles in 1949, he won acclaim for his exuberant, unique structures, from cubist-inspired early buildings to the more curvilinear later works. One of his most celebrated achievements is the titanium-clad Guggenheim Museum in Bilbao (opposite, 1991–7), which appears as an intrinsic part of the urban surroundings, and also as a sculpture. A similarly sculptural design is his Vitra Design Museum (1987–9) in Weil am Rhein, Germany, clad in white stucco and zinc, which jumbles horizontals and verticals. His acoustically sophisticated, curving stainless-steel Walt Disney Concert Hall in Los Angeles (1999–2003) has become a landmark, and his Nationale-Nederlanden building in Prague (1992–6), known as the ‘Dancing House’ or ‘Fred and Ginger’, was a collaboration with Vlado Milunić (b.1941) and appears to dance between its baroque and art nouveau neighbours.

